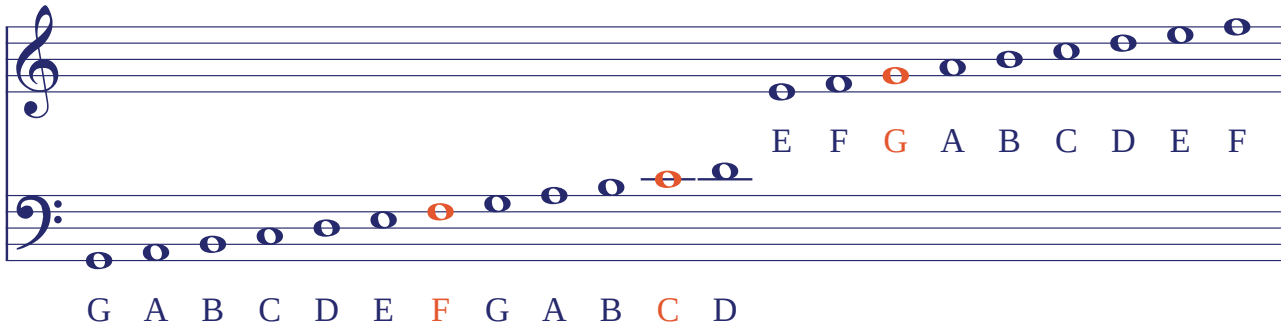
PART I · PITCH · 4

Reading the notes

Every line and space has one letter. You do not have to learn them all at once: start from a note you always know, then **step** or **skip** to the one you want.

THE SECRET

Start from a note you know (bass F, Middle C, treble G), then step or skip.



Middle C in the middle; treble G and bass F, the clef notes, either side. Every line and space is the next letter.

THE RULE

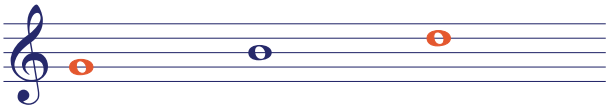
Step: to the very next line or space (one letter on). Skip: line to the next line, or space to the next space (two letters on).

Words to remember the lines and spaces

STAFF	LINES (BOTTOM TO TOP)	SPACES (BOTTOM TO TOP)
Treble	**E G B D F**: *Every Good Boy Deserves Fun*	**F A C E**: they spell *FACE*
Bass	**G B D F A**: *Great Big Dragons Fly Away*	**A C E G**: *All Cows Eat Grass*

EXAMPLE 1

Read a note you are not sure of



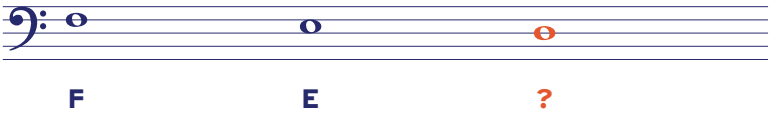
1. **The clef:** treble, so the clef note is G, on line 2.
2. **From G, skip up** line to line: one letter jumped each time.
3. **Count the skips** up to the other red note, on line 4: G, then B, then ...

The red note is **D**: G, B, D, two skips up from the clef's G.

PART I · PITCH · 4 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 2

Read a bass note from the clef



1. **The bass clef's dots** sit either side of line 4: that line is F.
2. **Step down** to the space below.
3. **One more step down** to the red note on line 3.

F, E, **D**: bass line 3 is D, two steps down from the clef's F.

EXAMPLE 3

One line, two notes

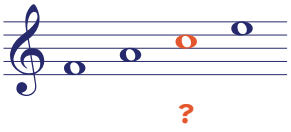


1. **Look at the red notes:** both sit on the bottom line.
2. **Now look at the clefs:** treble on the left, bass on the right.
3. **Read each from its clef note:** treble G is line 2, so step down (F in the space) to line 1; bass F is line 4, so step down line by line.

Treble bottom line: **E**. Bass bottom line: **G**. Same line, different note: always read the **clef** first.

EXAMPLE 4

Find Treble C on the staff



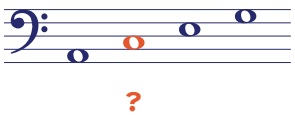
1. **These notes sit in the spaces.** The bottom space is F.
2. **Step up through the spaces:** F, A … they spell a word.
3. **The red note is space 3.** Which letter is it?

F A **C** E: space 3 is **C**, Treble C, the same C you found on the keyboard, one octave above Middle C.

PART I · PITCH · 4 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 5

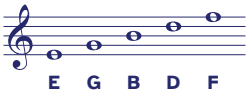
Find Bass C on the staff



1. **These notes sit in the bass spaces.** The bottom space is A: *All.*
2. **Say the next word:** *All Cows …*
3. **The red note is space 2.** Which letter?

A **C** E G: space 2 of the bass staff is **C**, Bass C, one octave below Middle C.

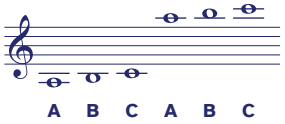
TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



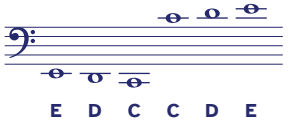
Say the treble lines up and down.

"E G B D F", then "F D B G E", out loud, as fast as you can without a slip. Then the spaces: "F A C E".

Ledger lines: the staff carried on



Treble: A, B, C below; A, B, C above.



Bass: E, D, C below; C, D, E above.

Notes too high or too low for the staff sit on short extra lines called **ledger lines**, spaced exactly like the staff lines. Read them by stepping on from the nearest staff line: line, space, line, space.

EXAMPLE 6

Read a high note on ledger lines



1. **The top line** of the treble staff is F.
2. **Step up** one note at a time: G sits on top of the staff, A on the first ledger line.
3. **Keep stepping** to the red note: B above it, then the second ledger line.

Two ledger lines above the treble staff: **High C**, two octaves above Middle C.

PART I · PITCH · 4 · CONTINUED

EXTRA · GOING FURTHER

Too many ledger lines? 8va

Very high notes need lots of ledger lines, and lots of ledger lines are hard to read. So a high passage is often written lower, with **8va** and a dotted line above it: play those notes **one octave higher** (eight notes up, from a C to the next C, p. 23) until the dotted line stops. **8vb** under the notes means an octave lower.

GAME

Name it from the clef note
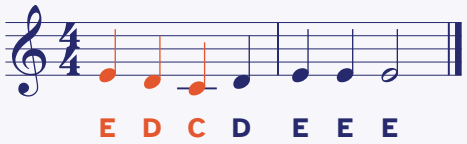
1	2	3	4
treble line 3	treble space 1	bass line 3	bass space 3

Start from the clef note (treble G on line 2, bass F on line 4), then step or skip.

Answer: 1 B (skip up from G) · 2 F (step down from G) · 3 D (two steps down from F) · 4 E (step down from F).

YOU KNOW THIS

Mary Had a Little Lamb



E D C: **line, space, Middle C's own little line**, one step down each time. Read the shape and the tune walks down with it.

Try it. Read the notes aloud before you play them.

THINK OF IT The clef notes are lamp posts on a dark road: walk from the nearest one and you are never lost.

TRAP

- × Naming bass notes with treble names: in the bass, the bottom line is G, not E.
- × Mixing up step and skip: a step changes line to space; a skip stays on lines (or on spaces).
- × Reading ledger lines from the wrong end: step out from the staff.

SEE ALSO

The staff and the clefs p. 27 · The staff and the keyboard p. 29

PRACTISE IT

Workbook Pitch 4 · Online: Line and Space Names · Steps & Skips · Ledger Lines